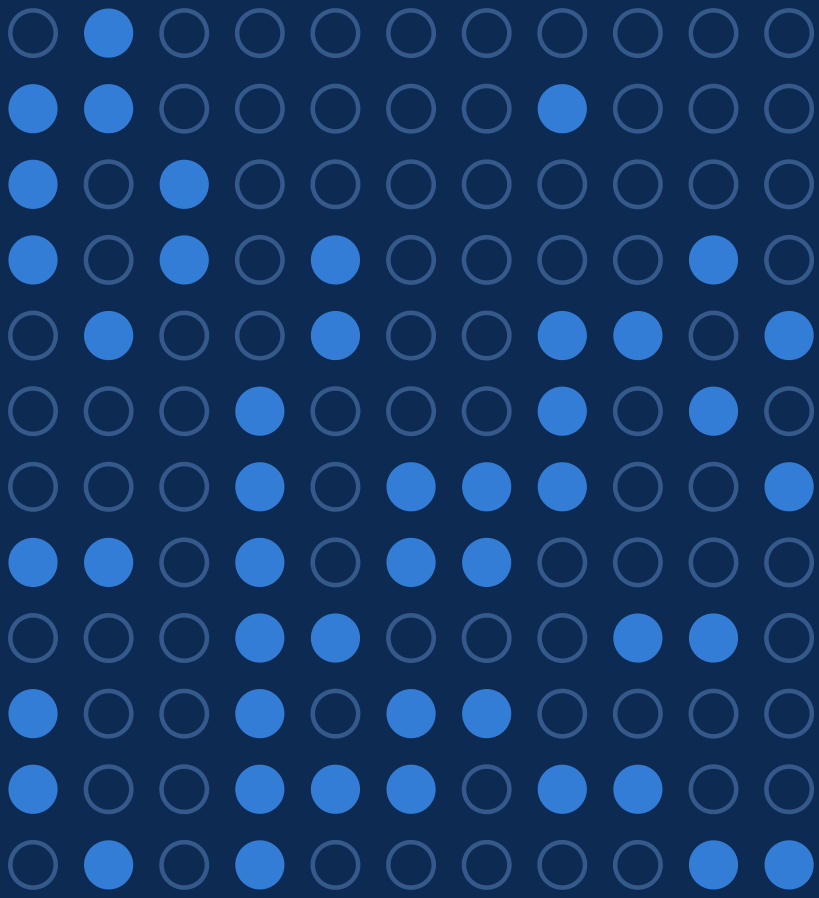
SLATE RESEARCH · DATA STUDY 02

The Quota Tax

What AI visibility tracking really costs once you price in statistics, cadence and clients. Eleven plans, four units of cost, one buyer's checklist.



November 2026

Pricing analysis of AI search visibility platforms

slatehq.com

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The price on the page is the smallest cost of a quota

AI visibility tools are compared on price per prompt. That is the least informative unit available. Prices per answer differ by about 4x across the market. Two other costs are much larger: how long a fixed cadence makes you wait before a number can be trusted, and how per-workspace pricing grows with every client or brand you add. We call these the quota tax.

10.8 mo

to reach a ±5-point reading on one prompt and one engine at a fixed once-daily cadence. A 10-prompt topic gets there in about 11 days.

$3.99

per tracked prompt per month on Profound's 100-prompt tier. That is the highest list price per prompt among the plans we compared.†

$4,089

per month to track 10 agency clients on Profound's per-workspace agency pricing, before any extra engine.†

0

published Profound plans for brands between a 7-day trial and a custom Enterprise contract, since September 2026.†

Key findings

- **Price per answer ranges from about $0.02 to $0.08.** A decision-grade reading on one prompt (±10 points) costs between $1 and $7 in answers on any plan. The dollars are not what limits you.
- **Cadence is what limits you.** With a fixed once-daily run, one prompt-engine collects 30 answers a month, regardless of budget. Faster certainty comes from pooling engines, grouping prompts into topics, or buying more runs on the prompts that matter.
- **Per-workspace pricing grows linearly with clients.** On reported figures, an agency pays $99 plus $399 for each client on Profound. A flat agency plan becomes cheaper at about five clients, if its allowances cover the book.
- **Extra engines cost most where they matter most.** Reports say Claude, Gemini and Copilot tracking require a Profound Enterprise contract. Slate lists them as a $100/month add-on.†

Disclosure

Slate sells an AI visibility and execution platform and appears in this analysis. Slate is not the cheapest per answer at list price, and we say so. All prices are dated November 2026; figures marked † are third-party reported.

CONTEXT

The pricing ladder moved under buyers' feet

Profound, the category's best-funded vendor, has changed how brands buy it three times in sixteen months. A mid-market team that budgeted from a published price in early 2026 now gets a short trial and a sales conversation.

JUN 2025

$499 / mo

"Profound Lite" self-serve plan announced with the $20M Series A.

EARLY–MID 2026

$99 · $399

Starter (50 prompts, ChatGPT only) and Growth (100 prompts, 3 engines), billed annually only.†

MID-SEP 2026

Removed

Brand self-serve plans reportedly withdrawn the same week as the $180M Series D.†

NOV 2026

Trial → quote

7-day trial, then custom Enterprise. Third parties estimate $2k–$5k+/mo; a secondhand Vendr median is about $34.5k/yr.†

The rest of the market still publishes prices. Otterly, Peec, Scrunch, AthenaHQ, Ahrefs Brand Radar, Semrush and Slate all list self-serve tiers, which lets us normalize them. Agencies can still buy Profound self-serve, at a reported $99 a month plus $399 per client workspace.

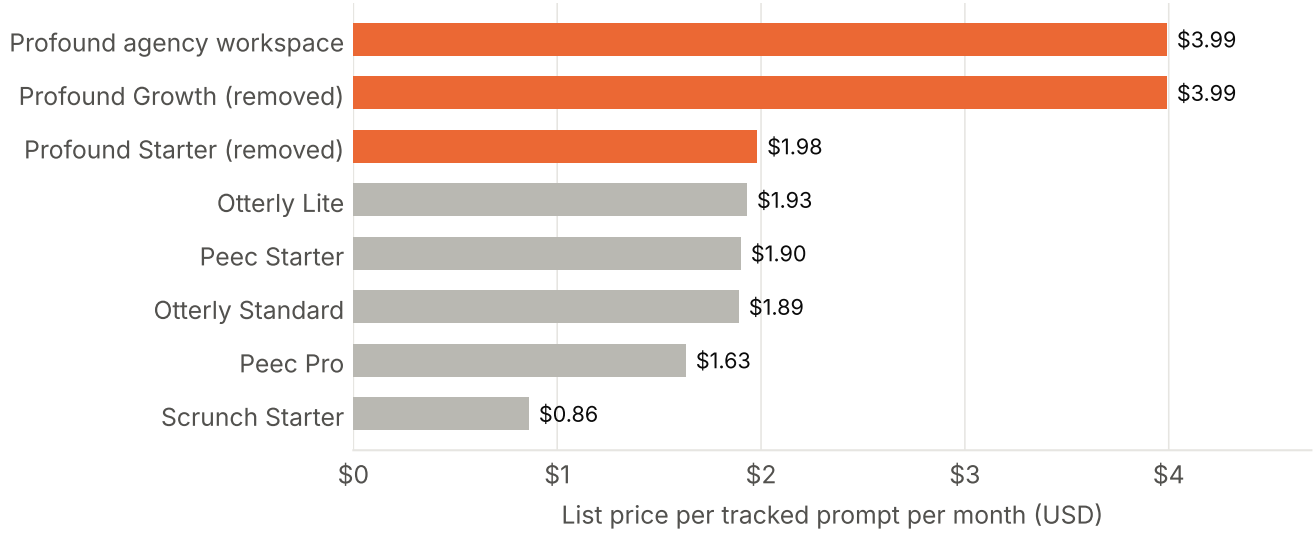
Four ways to price a quota

Unit	What it answers	Why it misleads on its own
Per tracked prompt	What one question costs to watch	Hides how many answers, engines and runs each prompt gets
Per sampled answer	The real unit of evidence	Says nothing about whether you can put answers where you need them
Per decision-grade reading	What a trustworthy number costs	Cheap everywhere; the binding limit is time, not dollars
Per month to confidence	How long until a change can be called	Depends on cadence and pooling, which few vendors disclose

UNITS 1 AND 2

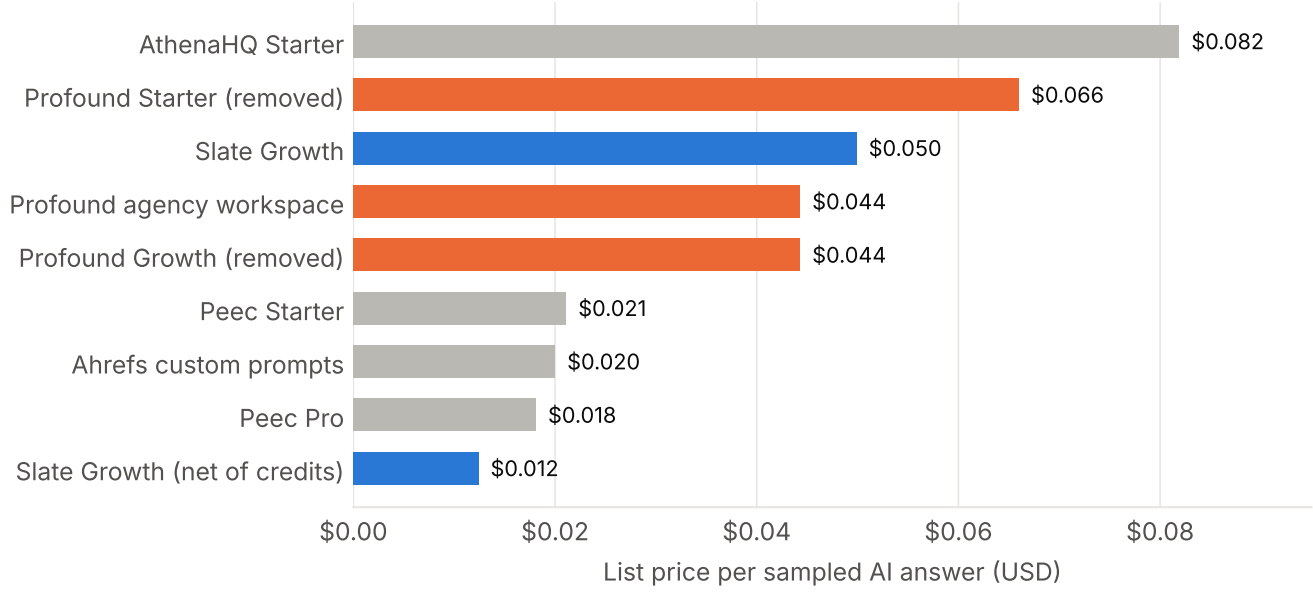
Price per prompt and price per answer rank vendors differently

Figure 1 · List price per tracked prompt per month



Monthly list price divided by included prompts. Plans priced by answers or credits (AthenaHQ, Ahrefs custom prompts, Slate) don't have a prompt unit and are excluded. Orange = Profound, gray = other vendors. †

Figure 2 · List price per sampled AI answer



Monthly list price divided by answers collected (prompts × engines × runs, or stated answer and credit allowances). "Net of credits" subtracts the value of the 15,000 execution credits bundled with Slate Growth, at Slate's $125 per 5,000 top-up rate. Blue = Slate. †

Slate is not the cheapest per answer at list price. At $0.050 per answer, Slate Growth costs slightly more than Profound's $0.044. Slate's case rests on what else the spend buys: unlimited prompts, a fourth engine (Google AI Mode), 1,000 monitored pages, and execution credits for content, audits and fixes. Net of those credits, tracking costs about $0.012 per answer. Any comparison that quotes only a per-prompt price for a credit-based plan is comparing different things.

UNITS 3 AND 4

A trustworthy number costs a few dollars and several months

A reading you can act on needs enough answers. At a 30% appearance rate, ±10 points needs 81 answers and ±5 points needs 323 (see *The Coin-Flip Report*). The dollar cost of those answers is small on every plan:

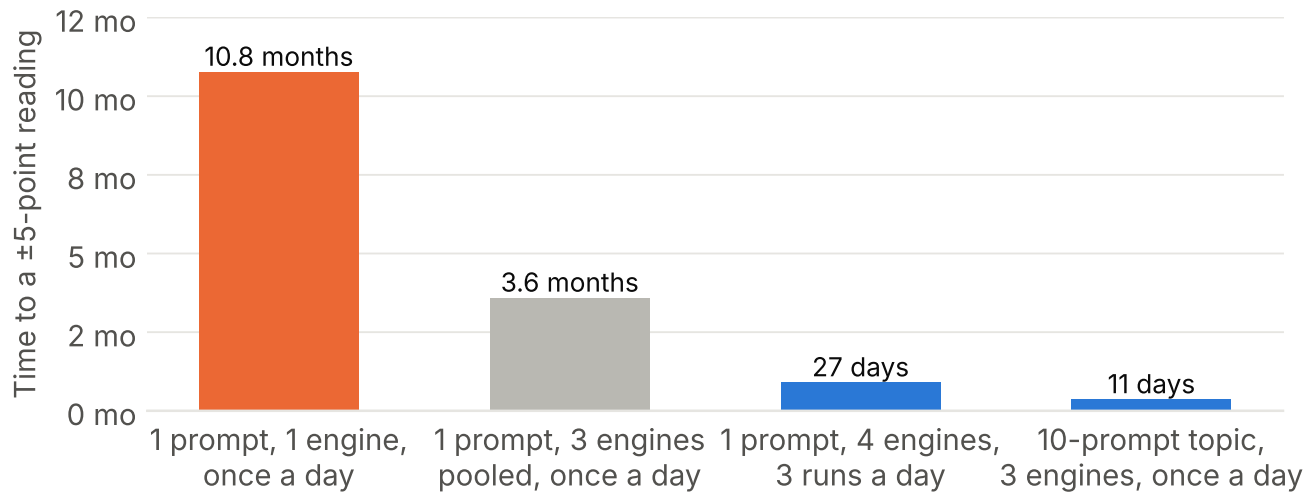
Plan	$ / answer	Cost of a ±10-pt reading	Cost of a ±5-pt reading	Months to ±10 pts at fixed daily	Months to ±5 pts at fixed daily
Profound agency workspace	$0.044	$3.59	$14.32	2.7	10.8
Slate Growth (gross)	$0.050	$4.04	$16.12	—	—
Slate Growth (net of credits)	$0.012	$1.00	$4.01	—	—
AthenaHQ Starter	$0.082	$6.64	$26.47	—	—
Peec Starter	$0.021	$1.71	$6.82	2.7	10.8
Ahrefs custom prompts	$0.020	$1.62	$6.46	—	—

Per prompt on one engine. "Fixed daily" applies where a plan runs each prompt once a day per engine; it is left blank where the allocation is not fixed. †

The constraint is time. A plan that runs each prompt once a day collects 30 answers a month for that prompt on that engine, no matter how much the buyer would pay for more. The only ways to get a confident reading faster are pooling (several engines, or several prompts in one topic) or more runs per day on the prompts that matter.

> **The quota tax, defined**
>
> The cost of a fixed quota is mostly paid in time. A team that can't move sampling depth onto the prompts it is fixing waits months to learn whether the fix worked, and spends that time acting on noise.

Figure 3 · Time to a ±5-point reading, by sampling design



Answers needed (323) divided by answers collected per month under each design. A 10-prompt topic on three engines sampled daily reaches ±5 points in about 11 days. One prompt on one engine takes almost a year.

AGENCIES AND MULTI-BRAND TEAMS

Per-workspace pricing grows with every client

Agencies and multi-brand companies pay the quota tax per brand. On reported figures, Profound's agency pricing is $99 a month plus $399 per client workspace, each covering 100 prompts on three engines, run daily.† Ten clients cost $4,089 a month; twenty cost $8,079; thirty cost $12,069. Claude and Gemini coverage is not included at that price.

Figure 4 · Monthly tracking cost by number of client workspaces



Per-client lines assume one plan per client at list price. Slate's Agency plan is reported at $2,000 a month flat. Its client and answer allowances were not public at the time of writing, so the crossover (about five clients) holds only if the allowances cover the book. †

Three things per-client pricing changes

1. **Small retainers get under-tracked.** When every client costs $399 in software, a $2,000 retainer either absorbs a 20% tool cost or gets dropped from tracking.
2. **Engine choices are made per client.** If extra engines sit behind Enterprise, the agency decides by budget, not by where each client's buyers search.
3. **The vendor's AI products compete with the agency's work.** Profound pays certified agency partners while marketing an "AI Marketer" that finds earned-media opportunities and refreshes content. Agencies should check where that line falls before building a practice on it.

FOR BUYERS

The quota checklist: twelve questions before you sign

- [ ] How many answers per prompt, per engine, per month does the plan collect? Get it in writing.
- [ ] Is the run cadence fixed, or can I put more runs on priority prompts?
- [ ] Can I group prompts into topics and trend the topic?
- [ ] Which engines are included, and what does each additional engine cost, published or quoted?
- [ ] What happens at the quota: hard stop, overage charge, or forced upgrade?
- [ ] Is billing monthly or annual-only? What are the auto-renewal and notice terms?
- [ ] For agencies: is pricing per workspace or per pooled allowance? Is white-label reporting included?
- [ ] Does trial data carry over into the paid plan? Can I export raw answers?
- [ ] Who owns my prompt history and answer archive if I leave?
- [ ] Does the price include doing the work (content, corrections, outreach), or only the measurement?
- [ ] Is collection by API or from the consumer app, and from which location?
- [ ] What is the smallest change your reports treat as real?

> **How to use this**
>
> Normalize every quote to price per answer, then work out how long your top 20 prompts take to reach ±10 points under the vendor's cadence. If the answer is "a quarter," you will be reviewing noise for a quarter.

METHODOLOGY AND SOURCES

How prices were normalized

All prices are monthly list prices in USD as reported between September and November 2026. Answers per month = prompts × engines × 30 daily runs, unless a plan states an answer or credit allowance. Profound's Enterprise pricing is unpublished; third-party estimates are shown as estimates, never as list prices. Slate's net-of-credits figure values bundled credits at the published top-up rate and is shown alongside the gross figure. Decision-grade readings use a 30% baseline and normal-approximation sample sizes (81 for ±10 points, 323 for ±5 points).

Plan	Price / mo	Prompts	Answers / mo	Basis
Otterly Lite	$29	15	450	15 prompts; answers assume 1 engine daily
Otterly Standard	$189	100	—	100 prompts
Peec Starter	$95	50	4,500	50 prompts, 3 models, daily
Peec Pro	$245	150	13,500	150 prompts, 3 models, daily
Scrunch Starter	$300	350	—	350 prompts (sources conflict)
AthenaHQ Starter	$295	—	3,600	3,600 credits = 3,600 responses
Ahrefs custom prompts	$50	—	2,500	add-on: 2,500 checks; base plan may be required
Profound Starter (removed)	$99	50	1,500	50 prompts, ChatGPT, daily; removed Sep 2026
Profound Growth (removed)	$399	100	9,000	100 prompts, 3 engines, daily; removed Sep 2026
Profound agency workspace	$399	100	9,000	per client, +$99/mo agency base
Slate Growth	$499	—	10,000	unlimited prompts; 10,000 answers; +15,000 execution credits

Sources

1. Profound Lite launch: PR Newswire, Jun 2025.
2. Profound $99/$399 annual-only plans and removal: Get-Ryze; Trakkr; CitePrism; eClincher.
3. Profound Enterprise estimates: GeoToolbox; MartechVerdict; Vendr median via Reoptimize (secondhand).
4. Profound agency workspace pricing: Tools8020; Trakkr agency.
5. Competitor pricing: Prefer; AI Ranked; Arahi; Sightivo.
6. Slate pricing: slatehq.com/pricing; slatehq.com/slate-vs-profound.
7. Profound AI Marketer description: Search Engine Watch.

© 2026 Slate. Prices change often; check each vendor's current pricing before buying. Figures marked † are third-party reported, dated November 2026.